

78 YEARS OF INDEPENDENCE

"MY STAFF WORKED ON LOWER SALARIES AND BUILDING MATERIAL WAS PURCHASED ON CREDIT. AFTER THE FLOODS, IT TOOK ME THREE YEARS TO REPAY THE SALARIES AND LOANS"

SHYAMENDRA SINGH

banks of the Ken in Panna district. The Panna National Park had been notified some years before and Madla was one of the entry gates. Ken River Lodge was born with four mud huts on 2.5 acres of farmland that year. Twelve months into the business, Shyamendra bought out the major's share and decided to go solo.

Since then, Ken River Lodge has diversified into a 50-acre property with 26 rooms. But it was a journey marked with challenges. In 1992, the Ken river broke the banks and everything was washed away in the floods. Shyamendra then decided on a low investment model and set up tents. He added 10 rooms four years later and everything seemed fine till 2005 when the next big flood struck. By that time, the property had expanded to 16 rooms, but again he lost almost everything. "That was a turning point in my life. I had to decide whether to pack up and leave or make another attempt to bounce back," says Shyamendra. Finally, 'bouncing back' was what he chose. Within six months, he rebuilt the property and had it ready by the next tourist season. "My staff worked on lower salaries and building material was purchased on credit. It took me three years to pay the salaries and repay loans," he says.

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Ken River Lodge

What it does: **The first tourism property in Madla, it has helped transform the village's economy**

Founded in: **1986**

Annual turnover
Rs 4.5 crore

Shyamendra and wife Bhavna Kumari still manage the day-to-day operations at the lodge. The crisis also prompted him to expand his business to other reserves, establishing Tree House Hideaway and King's Lodge in Bandhavgarh (2006) and Earth Lodge in Kanha (2008). His friend Manav Khanduja, who had been handling the marketing for Ken River Lodge, came on board and the two set up Pugdundee Safaris in 2008. Since then, Pugdundee has added three more properties in Tadoba, Satpura and Pench Tiger Reserves along with other partners. The total turnover of all seven properties together is around Rs 30 crore.

Shyamendra was nominated to the MP wildlife advisory board in 2009 and is now working on getting the Parasmania forest, a corridor between the Panna and Bandhavgarh reserves, declared a conservation reserve. "When I first came to Madla, people said you were making a mistake. But from a sleepy village of 800 people in 1986, it has transformed to one which has 50 safari vehicles and eight jungle lodges. The total turnover from tourism is now around Rs 20 crore here," he says. Fair to say that Shyamendra's journey into the wild has touched a lot of lives in this little corner of Panna. ■